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### How to Reframe Your Shame.

People often confuse guilt with shame and they're closely related on the surface.

Guilt involves feeling bad about something regardless of whether anyone knows. It might include, you made a bad choice and opt to do better in the future, simply because you want to be a better person.

Shame on the other hand involves a deep rooted fear that someone's going to find out what you've done and judge you harshly.

Consequently, Shame might cause you to lie and destroy any evidence that you messed up because you are desperate to preserve your reputation..

Scientists can see the difference in the brain when they examine people who experience guilt versus shame. In MRIs shame sets off high activity in the right area of the brain, but not in the amygdala. Guilt activates the amygdala in the frontal lobe which ultimately means that shame is just a much more complex emotion.

Keep in mind that **guilt can be healthy**. If you feel guilty that you yelled at someone, for example, you might make an effort to keep your cool next time. **Shame isn't healthy**. However, it causes us to hide things and it reinforces unhealthy beliefs about ourselves like I'm not good enough. That leads us to believe that we just aren't capable of doing any better. So rather than think I made a bad choice or something bad happened to me. You'll believe I'm a bad person, but we often confuse the two.

If you believe that you're a competent, capable person who's good enough, you'll make healthy decisions for yourself. If you believe you're a bad person and you invest a lot of time into covering up the things that you do, you'll struggle to create your best life.

There are lots of things that we might feel shame about. Some common reasons are sexually abuse, being in an abusive relationship, cheating on someone, or even having an eating disorder. Sometimes people might feel ashamed that they grew up in poverty or they had a parent with a serious mental illness. Other times shame stems from our behavior like maybe you feel shame over how you treated someone in the past. People feel shame about different things and to different degrees. Your personality and your upbringing play a big role in what you feel ashamed about.

If you were shamed as a kid, you were likely emotionally conditioned to feel shame and similar circumstances. Even when you have no responsibility for what happened. You might also be more likely to develop unhealthy beliefs about yourself and those beliefs can trigger shame-based criticism.

By middle school, most kids emotional styles are pretty much established. Meaning whether you were more likely to experience guilt or shame back then can greatly influence how you feel now. As well as the action you take, kids who are more prone to shame are more likely to engage in unhealthy behaviors like unprotected sex or they're more likely to use illegal drugs in young adulthood. People who experience the highest degrees of shame are also more likely to develop substance abuse problems. They get stuck in a cycle that's hard to break. Let's say someone engages in their addiction and then they feel shame the next day. They're more likely to reach for whatever they're addicted to in an effort to ease their uncomfortable feelings and the cycle continues. Not everyone who experiences high degrees of shame develops and addiction. However, other people cope by using isolation or they keep people that are comfortable, emotional distance or they spend a lot of time going to great lengths to cover up things that they don't want people to see. So how do you break this cycle of shame? And what can you do about it? Brenae Brown is an expert on shame. She is a shame researcher and written several best selling books. She says shame needs three things to grow exponentially in our lives. Secrecy, silence and judgment. As for the antidote to shame, she says shame cannot survive being spoken, it cannot survive empathy. So what does that mean? The first step in overcoming shame is doing what likely scares you the most, telling someone about

whatever it is that you feel shame about. Opening up to someone who is empathetic will automatically reduce the amount of shame you feel. But that means you need to be careful about who you pick to share your story with. If your mother's going to ridicule you, don't tell her, talk to a friend who you trust won't judge you. You might start the conversation by explaining that what you're about to say is really tough to share and that you don't want any advice. You just want someone to listen. If you don't have someone that you can talk to, you might reach out to a Christian mental health professional as a therapist. I've heard lots of things over the years and I don't judge anyone for what they've done or what they've gone through, but I know how tough it is for people to share secrets for the first time. Some people just cry. Some of them didn't tell me the whole story at first. Some people it takes them years before they ever open up and tell you something about their shame and the thing that they've been hiding. After revealing something that caused them shame, a lot of people said they immediately felt better, but after a day or two some of them began to question whether it was really a good idea.

Something that Brené Brown refers to as a vulnerability hangover they worried about whether I'd still look at them the same when they return to therapy the following week. So we often address their concerns about this in treatment and once people realize that I could have appreciated them and not judge them, despite whatever they shared, they tended to feel a lot better. In fact, no one ever told me that they later regretted sharing.

If it feels too scary to tell someone you might start by writing your story in a journal. Just getting your story out of your head and onto a page might help you experience a little less shame and it might give you the courage you need to share your story with someone who can listen with empathy. So that's the best way to reframe your shame. Tell someone about the shame you feel and why you feel it. Bringing it to light can reduce your suffering.